version presents the prince's future as having been accurately predicted, again before he was born, by a religious personage who happened to be an Ajivika. When his mother was pregnant with him, her cravings for all kinds of unusual and odd things had apparently become a matter of concern for Bindusara. In this legend, the king first sought the assistance of the Brahmans in his court.[37] How many Brahmans he sought out is unknown, but they evidently failed to comprehend the queen's cravings. Eventually, it was Janasana, an Ajivika known to frequent the queen's family, who understood them and pronounced the political destiny of the unborn child as the future ruler of Jambudvipa. As a geographical term, Jambudvipa is sometimes used for an island, and at other times for the territory extending from the Himalayas in the north to the sea in the south.[38] We shall later see, by the time of Ashoka, as his own epigraphs underline, Jambudvipa meant the vast land that the emperor ruled. What is striking is that in this tale too the figure of an Ajivika ascetic is deployed to drive home the point that Ashoka was destined to be emperor of India.

Why an Ajivika acted as the augur and not, for instance, a Buddhist or a Jaina or even a Brahman sage, needs to be unravelled. Actually, a significant insight into this is offered by something we know about Ashoka from his own epigraphs: he actively patronized this sect after he ascended the throne of Pataliputra.[39] The caves that he donated to the Ajivikas at Barabar near Gaya are marked by his donative epigraphs. These elaborate caves and the king's carvings there will be examined at length later; here, it is worth pointing out that these were no ordinary caves but were created, through a substantial outlay of money and men, by hollowing out granitic outcrops.[40] Like the pillars that the emperor set up in various parts of his empire, their interiors were mirror polished, giving them uniquely glittering walls. The reasons for Ashoka making such a generous donation to the Ajivikas remain unknown but the memory of the emperor's patronage of this sect must certainly have survived him. So, for later composers of